

AFRICAN WILDLIFE



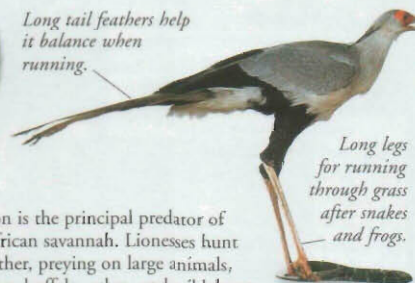
NO OTHER CONTINENT matches the wealth of wildlife found in Africa. Covering the full climatic spectrum from intense heat to bitter cold, its varied vegetation has given rise to a wide range of animals, including mammals, birds, reptiles, fish, and insects. Among them are more than 40 species of primate, ranging from tiny galagos to huge gorillas, a great variety of antelopes, gazelles, and other hoofed animals, and 70 species of carnivore. Bird life, too, is extraordinarily rich; more than 1,500 species live south of the Sahara. In addition, Africa is inhabited by the world's fastest land animal, the cheetah; the biggest bird, the ostrich; and the largest land animal, the elephant.

Grassland wildlife

African grasslands (savannahs) sustain over 20 species of grazing animals, from the giant sable antelope to the tiny pygmy antelope. The herds of plains game and their predators, including lions, are pursued by scavengers such as hyenas and vultures. Grassland birds include the guinea fowl and hornbills.



Long tail feathers help it balance when running.



Long legs for running through grass after snakes and frogs.

Lion

The lion is the principal predator of the African savannah. Lionesses hunt together, preying on large animals, such as buffalo, zebra, and wildebeest.



Zebras call to each other while grazing.

Zebra

Zebras usually live in family groups of 5–20 animals, but in the dry season they may gather in herds of a few hundred, for protection against predators such as lions. Male zebras defend themselves by kicking out with their legs and hooves. Zebras eat the tough tops of the grasses.

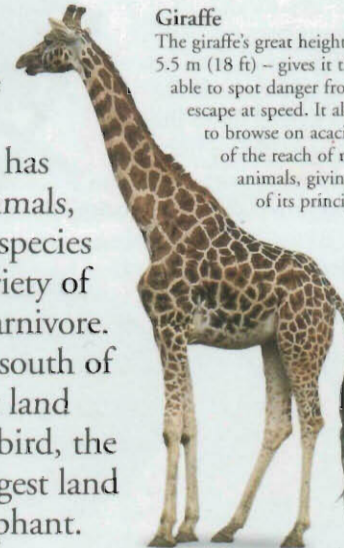


Aardvark

The aardvark is a solitary, nocturnal animal. It uses its powerful claws to break into the nests of ants and termites, which it extracts with its long, sticky tongue. The aardvark can dig at an astonishing speed – faster than a person with a shovel.

Giraffe

The giraffe's great height – males reach up to 5.5 m (18 ft) – gives it the advantage of being able to spot danger from a distance and then escape at speed. It also enables the giraffe to browse on acacia leaves that are out of the reach of most other grassland animals, giving it a near monopoly of its principal food supply.



Patterned coat provides camouflage.

Long tail with coarse hair is used to deter flies.

Secretary bird

Among the most striking of Africa's grassland birds is the secretary bird, with its long legs and feathered crest. It rarely flies, preferring to walk, nodding its head with each step. It attacks snakes, spreading its wings over its body to shield itself from venomous bites, while using its feet to stamp them to death.

Papyrus

The most common plant in African swamps is papyrus. It grows in clumps, often dense enough to support the weight of large animals.

Papyrus may reach 4.5 m (15 ft) in height.



Wetland wildlife

Africa's wetlands are seething with wildlife, such as crocodiles, hippos, floodplain species such as lechwes, and fish, including the Nile perch and tiger fish. The wetlands also provide stopping places for migratory birds flying south to winter in Africa.

Hippopotamus

Hippos spend most of the day submerged in water, with only their ears, eyes, and nostrils above the surface. They become active at dusk when they emerge from the water to graze on nearby grassland.

Cichlid fish

Lakes Malawi and Tanganyika contain 265 different species of cichlid (mouth-brooding fish); all but five are unique to Africa. Great depth, isolation, and few predators have resulted in this proliferation.



Lesser flamingo

Three million flamingos gather at Lake Nakuru, in Kenya, forming an amazing spectacle. They feed on the plentiful algae that flourish in the salty water, sunlight, and high temperatures in and around the lake.



Long legs for wading through water.

Webbed feet